

It didn't begin with a storm; it began with a beautiful, breathless quiet. A gentle rewriting of my heartbeat until you were the only riot.

You learned the map of my vulnerabilities, tracing them like a guide, Making yourself the only sanctuary where I could legally abide. But sanctuaries can turn into tombs when the doors are locked from the outside, And by the time the shadows grew long, there was nowhere left to hide.

You became the wound I protected, the ache I carried, the grief I chose. I knew your love left bruises behind, yet I watered every dying rose.

I learned to sleep in the spaces where your affection used to be, Trading the warmth of a real embrace for the cold grace of a memory. I built an altar out of your neglect, kneeling before an empty throne, Terrified that if I stopped kneeling, I would have to face the dark alone.

I practiced your absence before you even left, mastering the art of the ghost, Learning how to need you the least right when I actually needed you the most. I counted the hours by the weight of your unresponsiveness, a heavy, static hum, Staring at a screen like a prophet waiting for a revelation that would never come. I shrank myself into a footnote in your story, a quiet, convenient little phrase, Willing to be entirely invisible if it meant I could occasionally catch your gaze.

You were never entirely mine, but neither were you completely gone. So I kept rebuilding tomorrow from pieces of promises already withdrawn. I watched you slip through my fingers like water, yet I blamed my hands for the spill, Begging a shadow to hold me, pretending a phantom could cure the chill. How easily you became my air, how quietly you became my drought, Leaving me with a throat full of ashes from names I was forced to choke out.

I wore your inconsistencies like jewelry, showing off the chaos as a prize, Telling anyone who tried to save me that they just couldn't see through your eyes. I became a stranger to my own reflection, a shell hollowed out by your whim, Drowning in the middle of a shallow puddle just because I wanted you to swim. You offered me the world in whispers, then took it back in broad daylight, Leaving me to negotiate with the dark just to make it through another night.

I learned your silences thoroughly, memorized every shadow and disguise. Still searching abandoned hallways for warmth inside familiar lies. You loved me enough to linger, never enough to finally stay. Leaving breadcrumbs of affection whenever I started finding my way. A cruel choreography of coming and going, keeping me perpetually on my knees, Just enough light to keep me from blinding, just enough winter to make me freeze. You fed on my patience,

grew fat on my mercy, while I grew paper-thin, Scraping the bottom of an empty well just to taste where you had been.

The cruelest part wasn't losing you, it was believing loss could reverse. Turning every goodbye into prayer, every blessing into a curse. I held your absence carefully, treating it like something sacred and rare. Convincing myself devotion remained whenever your ghost appeared there. I guarded your exits like a soldier, making excuses for your retreat, Blaming the timing, the world, the stars, anything but your own two feet. I became an accomplice to my own destruction, rewriting the history of your abuse, Turning every deliberate silence into a tragedy I could easily excuse.

I kept a ledger of your generic kindness, inflating the value of every crumb, Pretending that a casual glance meant the real harvest was yet to come. I defended the very hands that suffocated me, explaining away the lack of air, Insisting that the marks around my neck were just a clumsy sign that you cared. I spent my sanity trying to decode the riddle of why I wasn't enough, Filing down all my sharp edges just so you wouldn't find my devotion too rough.

You taught me longing can survive long after certainty disappears from sight. How a heart can recognize disaster and still run toward the light. Some loves don't break all at once, they unravel thread by thread. Leaving traces of themselves inside every thought left unsaid. A slow hemorrhage of the soul, a quiet bleeding no one else could see, As I watched the version of myself who used to smile slowly cease to be. I traded my dignity for your company, a bargain struck in total despair, Only to realize I was buying an empty room and a handful of smoke-filled air.

I should have left when loving you started costing pieces of me. Instead I mistook surviving the storm for proof we were meant to be. Even now, your memory arrives wearing forgiveness I never received. And I hate how part of me still loves what another part has grieved. I am a haunted house of your making, a cemetery of things we never tried, Stuck in the middle of a civil war between the girl who left and the one who died.

And the worst realization isn't that you broke me beyond all repair,

It's that if you knocked on the door tonight, I'd still pull up a chair.

and for one terrible moment,

I'd call it fate instead of despair.